

Your Friendly Neighbourhood

Assessment 1 Project Proposal

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SDG: Goal 11 - Sustainable Cities and Communities

1. Project overview and SDG rationale

Your Friendly Neighbourhood is a decision-support website for renters who are new to Melbourne and unfamiliar with its areas. International students, new immigrants and interstate migrants are example personas of our target audience. Users will compare two or three Greater Melbourne SA2s using housing, transport, population growth and green-space indicators.

The interface will explain that an SA2 may represent one suburb, part of a suburb or several localities. The project supports SDG targets 11.1 (housing), 11.2 (transport), 11.3 (urbanisation) and 11.7 (green spaces).

We selected SDG 11 because Melbourne's growth is pressuring housing, transport and green space. The project helps renters compare these conditions before investigating where to live.

2. Issue, research and news evidence

Greater Melbourne gained approximately 105,000 residents, or 2%, during 2024-25, although growth varied substantially between areas (Australian Bureau of Statistics, 2026).

ABC News has reported infrastructure and service gaps in rapidly growing outer Melbourne. Domain reported rent increases across about three-quarters of Melbourne markets in 2025, while another Domain analysis found only eight suburbs within 10 kilometres of the CBD with median unit asking rents of \$500 or less. Affordability and location do not always coincide.

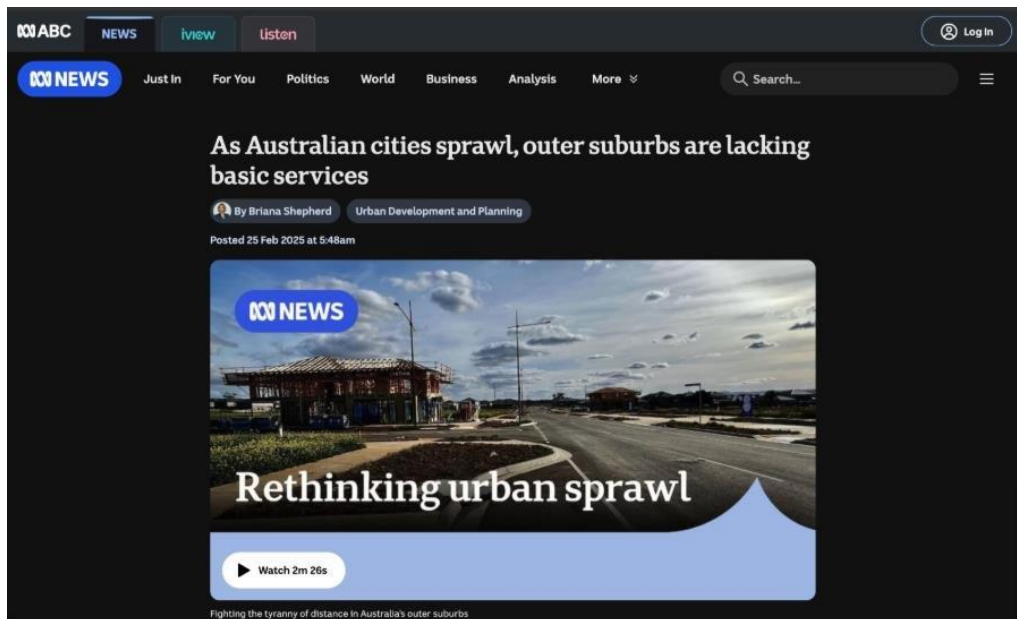


Figure 1: ABC News report on outer-suburban infrastructure and service gaps.

Our research found that the necessary open data is available but not immediately comparable. ABS data uses SA2 geography, while transport and open-space data require spatial processing.

3. Problem statement

A renter unfamiliar with Melbourne needs to compare selected SA2s consistently to balance housing affordability, transport access, population growth and green-space provision, but faces fragmented datasets with different formats, years, measures and boundaries.

The challenge is not missing information; it is turning fragmented information into a clear initial comparison.

4. Target audience and stakeholders

The single primary audience is renters who are new to Melbourne and unfamiliar with its areas, for example: international students, new immigrants and interstate. They need to understand area differences.

Other stakeholders include universities, Consumer Affairs Victoria, councils and communities.

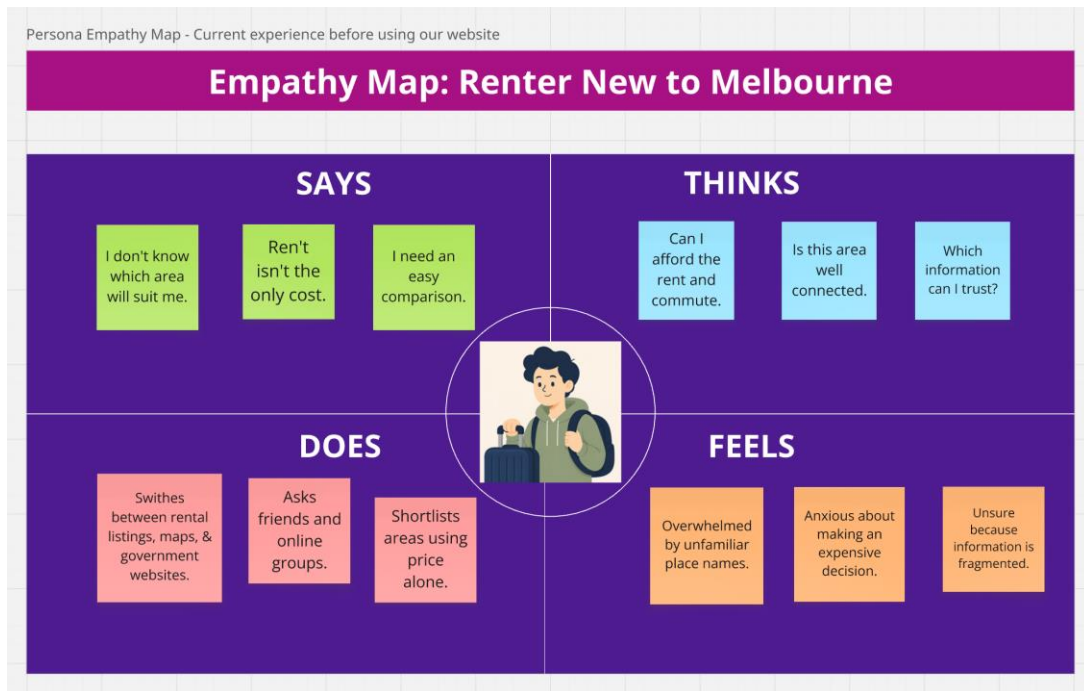


Figure 2: Current-state empathy map for a renter new to Melbourne.

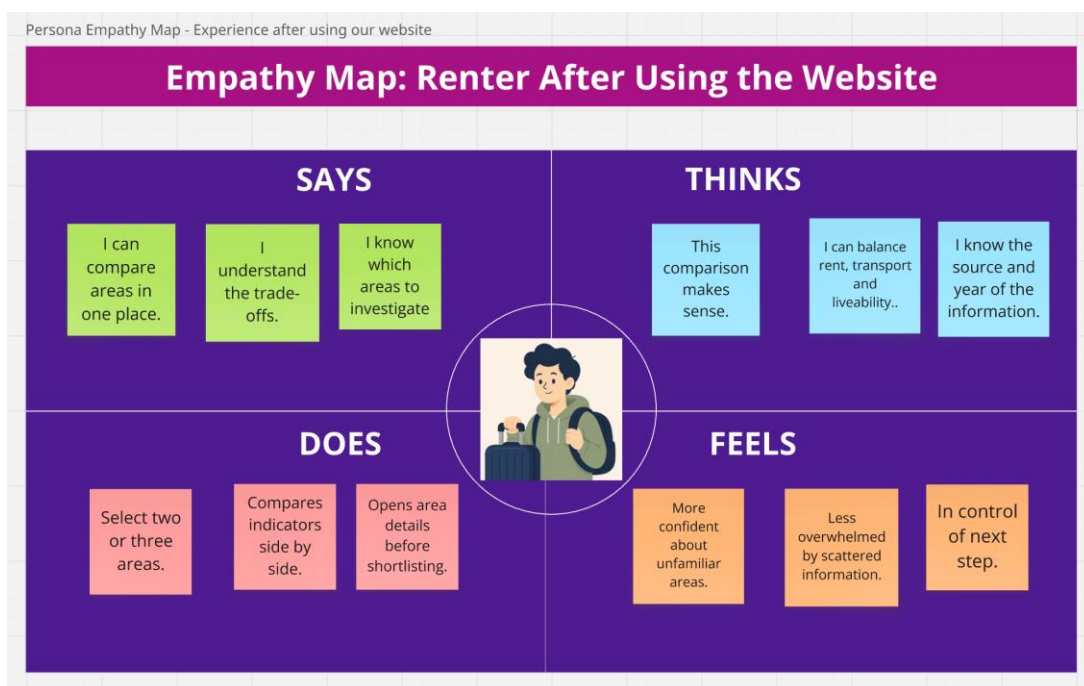


Figure 3: Future-state empathy map after using the website.

The empathy maps identify uncertainty, fragmented searching and price-only shortlisting. These findings informed side-by-side comparison and plain-language explanations help renters identify trade-offs.

5. Proposed solution and value

The website will contain:

- A Home page explaining its purpose and limitations
- A Compare page for selecting two or three SA2s
- An Area Details page showing indicators and trends

It will highlight trade-offs such as lower housing pressure with limited transport access. It will not rank areas, provide financial advice or tell renters where to live.

6. Open data and scoring logic

Proposed sources include:

The four indicators are renter-relevant, align with SDG 11 and are supported by public data. They show trade-offs rather than an overall suitability score.

1. ABS Regional Population
2. ABS 2021 Census DataPacks
3. DataVic Public Transport Accessibility Level
4. DataVic Metropolitan Melbourne Open Space
5. ABS SA2 boundaries for spatial preparation

The data will be cleaned and stored in a master database. Each indicator will become a percentile relative to eligible Greater Melbourne SA2s:

- **Growth pressure:** population growth rate and absolute increase
- **Housing pressure:** median rent relative to median household income
- **Transport access:** summarised PTAL result
- **Green-space provision:** open space per 1,000 residents

The website will use raw values and missing data will not equal zero.

7. User journey, epics and wireframes

The proposed journey is:

Learn about the product → select SA2s → compare indicators → open Area Details → review sources and limitations

A neighbourhood comparison tool for renters new to Melbourne

Find an area that better fits your everyday needs

Compare rent, transport, population and green-space information without searching through separate government datasets.

Search for a Melbourne area

Try Clayton, Carlton or Footscray

Start comparing

Areas are based on ABS SA2 statistical boundaries and may not exactly match suburb boundaries.

What you can compare



Rent and housing

Compare renter-relevant housing costs and pressure indicators.



Public transport

Understand relative access to public transport services.



Population change

See how quickly an area has recently grown or changed.



Green space

Review relative access to available open and green space.

Figure 4: Home page wireframe showing how renters can search for a Melbourne area and explore the four available comparison categories.

Compare Melbourne areas

Choose two or three SA2 areas and review renter-relevant information using the same measures.

Add an area

Add area

Clayton SA2

Footscray SA2

Add one more area

Comparison overview

Measure	Clayton SA2	Footscray SA2	What it means
Median weekly rent Housing - latest available year	\$480	\$520	Typical advertised or reported rent level for comparison.
Public transport access Relative area score	72 / 100 Stronger access	84 / 100 Stronger access	Relative access compared with eligible Melbourne SA2 areas.
Recent population growth Historical, not forecast	6.4%	3.1%	Indicates recent change that may affect demand for services and housing.
Green space per resident Square metres per person	18 m²	12 m²	A relative indication of available green and open space.

Scores are relative, based on open data and not a guarantee of personal suitability.

Continue exploring

Clayton SA2
Review values, sources, reference years and explanations for this area.

View Clayton details

Footscray SA2
Review values, sources, reference years and explanations for this area.

View Footscray details

Figure 5: Compare page wireframe.

[← Back to comparison](#)

Clayton SA2

A renter-focused summary of housing, transport, population change and green space.

An SA2 is a statistical area and may not exactly match the suburb boundary.

Area overview



Median weekly rent

\$480 per week

Typical reported rent level for area comparison.

Source: housing data · latest available year



Public transport access

72 / 100

Stronger access

Relative access compared with eligible Melbourne SA2s.

Source: PTAL data · source year shown in product



Recent population growth

6.4% five-year change

Shows recent area change; this is historical, not a forecast.

Source: ABS Regional Population · source years shown



Green space per resident

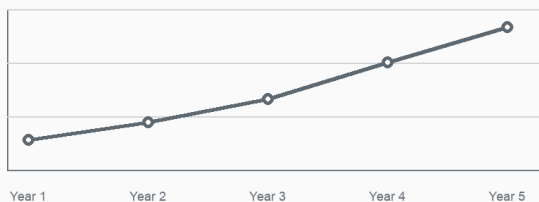
18 m² per person

Relative indication of available green and open space.

Source: DataVic Open Space · source year shown

Population trend

Five-year population change



What this may mean

The area has experienced population growth, which may increase demand for housing, transport and local services.

Interpret with the other indicators.

Before you decide

These results are relative area indicators, not a recommendation or guarantee of personal suitability. Check current listings, travel needs and local services before making a rental decision.

[Back to comparison](#)[Compare with another area](#)

Figure 6: Area Details page wireframe showing indicators and supporting explanations for selected Melbourne areas.

8. System architecture

The system will collect open datasets, clean and combine them in a database, apply consistent comparison logic and display the results through the website. The initial product will require no account and retain no personally identifiable information.

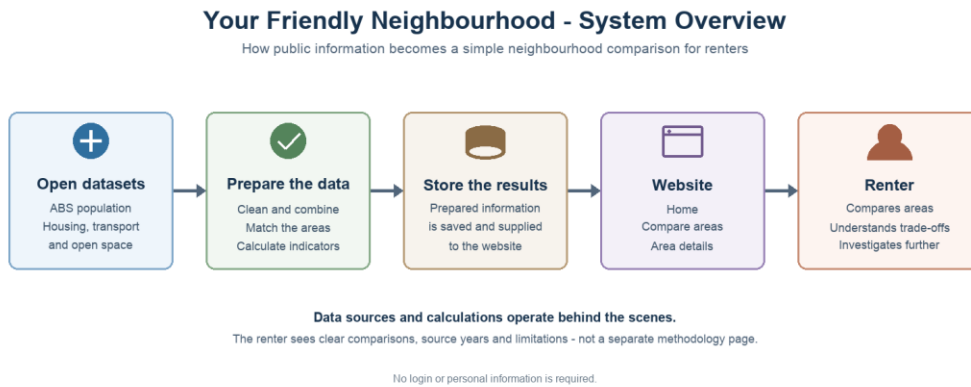


Figure 7: High-level system architecture.

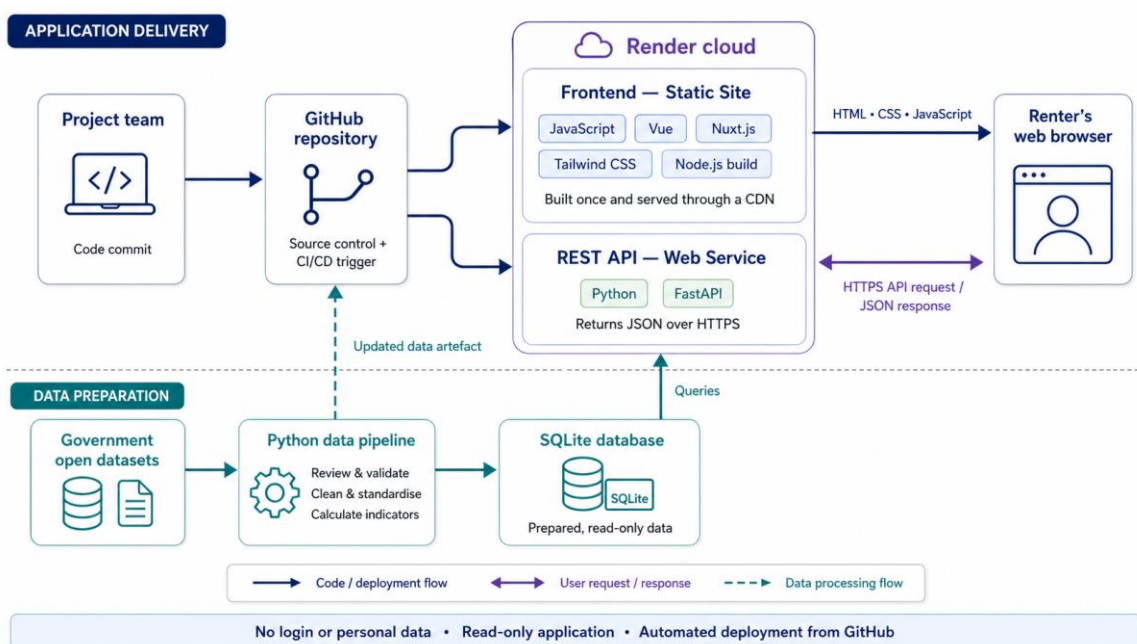


Figure 8: Technical system architecture showing data preparation.

9. Ethics and limitations

Risks include oversimplified ratings, indicators being mistaken for recommendations, inconsistent reference years, outdated or missing data, extreme percentages in small SA2s, community stigma and confusion between SA2 and suburb boundaries.

Safeguards include transparent calculations, source years, missing-data warnings, no overall "best area" score and advice to conduct further research. No personal information will be collected.

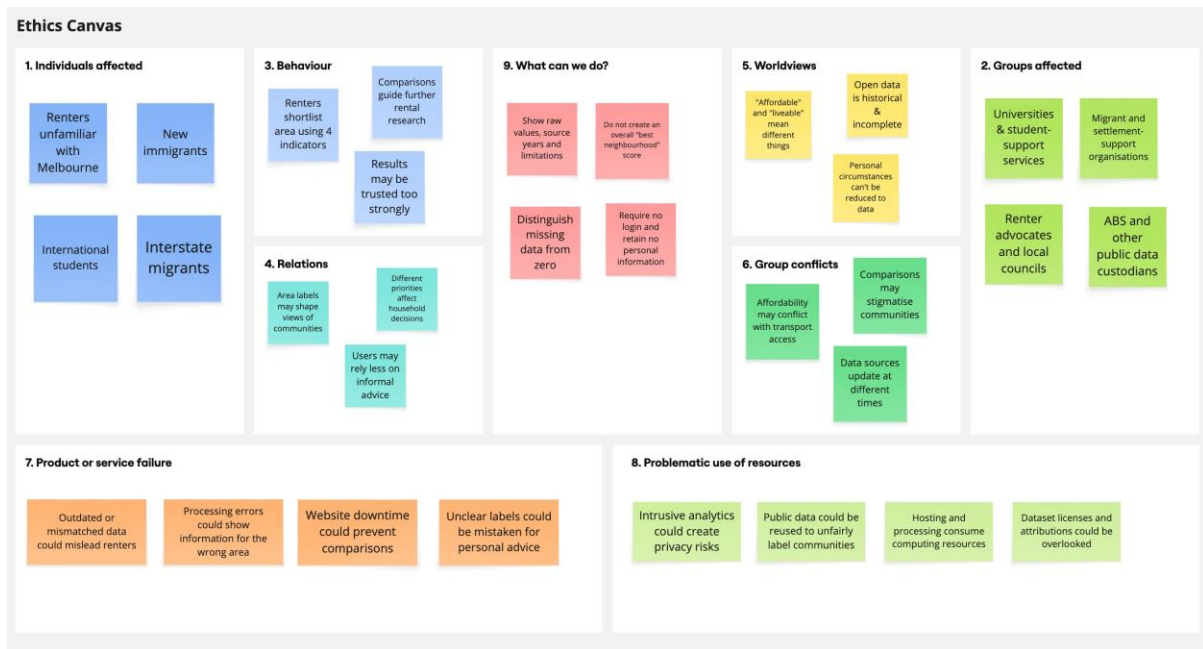


Figure 9: Ethics Canvas identifying affected stakeholders, potential ethical impacts and proposed safeguards for Your Friendly Neighbourhood.

10. Iteration 1 plan and success

Iteration 1 will deliver a deployed website using ABS population and housing data.

Deliverable	Acceptance condition
Home page	Purpose, audience and limitations are clear
Compare page	User can compare two SA2s
Area Details	Population trend and housing results are displayed
Database	Cleaned data can be retrieved by SA2 code
Deployment	Complete journey works on the hosted website

Success means the journey works without critical errors and at least four out of five test users can explain the indicators and identify one meaningful trade-off without assistance.

11. Potential sponsor

Consumer Affairs Victoria is a suitable potential sponsor because it supports Victorian renters. The project complements this role while users are deciding which areas to investigate. Study Melbourne, universities, settlement services or renter advocates could contribute testing and promotion.

12. Conclusion and feedback

Your Friendly Neighbourhood will turn fragmented open data into a transparent starting point for renters investigating unfamiliar Melbourne areas.

The team seeks feedback on the audience, indicators, SA2 geography, Iteration 1 feasibility and proposed sponsor.

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